

MARKHEMBROWEDITED

Travel Radio Australia and we're on the beautiful sunny Gold Coast. We're about 20 stories in the air here looking over the hinterland and the beach and I have one of the legends of Australian show business with me, Mark Hembrau. And Mark, welcome to the program.

Hey Jeff, good to be having a chat with you. I don't know about a legend. Everyone's a legend, I think.

Oh, you certainly are a legend. I've been looking back through your history. Now, let's go back to the beginning.

You're an Indooroopilly boy originally and here in Queensland, your mother Sally was a very influential lady in television in Australia. She was actually a producer at GTV9 on a national show and she must have been a huge influence on you. Yeah, Sally.

Yeah, she was one of the leaders in television in Queensland. She was the first one who had a women's television show. She compared and presented five days a week for, I think it was about 12 years in a row at Channel Nine up at Mount Coot-tha.

And that all came about when she was a very good cook and she was teaching cooking. Dad was studying and became a lecturer at university up there. And Channel Nine asked her to do a cooking show, interior decorating show, which she proceeded to go and do.

And yeah, she was very much a good old-fashioned mum, but she was a character and she did a lot of groundwork really. You had show business in the veins, wasn't it? Right from the very beginning, really. And after school, you hit Queensland Amateur Theatre and from there, you headed off to the bright lights of Sydney.

I didn't plan on being an actor and I didn't even plan about show business. Mum was just in the business and even though we'd go into town, we'd be recognised all over town. Hello, Sally.

I sort of grew up with it just normally, but I started working at advertising in Walton's Advertising in Brisbane when I was 16. And so I was there for six months and I bet I wouldn't go for an audition and this play. And it was a comedy and I went for this play and the character was a village idiot and apparently I was very good at playing a village idiot.

So I got the role in the show at Le Bois, which had just been built, Theatre in the Round. And I did a series of shows with them while I was working as the art director in Walton's Advertising. Yes, well, I decided to get a job because I wasn't going to school too much then.

I sort of liked school, but I liked gazing out the window and dreaming of other things at the time. My father was an academic, so it was quite interesting. And he said, look, I think you love the arts and you love painting and drawing and music and whatever.

He said, maybe you should get a job and then go down that road. And so I got a job and then I was working in Walton's Advertising for a little while. And then after being there for six months, there was a lady who was here from Canada had arrived and said, look, I'm involved in the theatre.

Would you like to come along? It was a bet, actually, for the matchmaker playing the role of Barnaby Tucker. And so I went there to Le Bois Theatre, which they'd built in the round. And I got in that show.

Then I did about four in a row. And then I did a few more at the arts show at the Arts Theatre. And it was obvious that obviously I was good at playing either village idiots or singing and playing funny characters at that early age.

And so what happened there is Queensland Theatre Company turned up and said, look, we've watched you in seven plays here and we want to offer you a job with the Queensland Theatre Company as a professional actor full time. And then I went on to do theatre and education. I did a show called Springle, which Billy Brown wrote.

It was a great playwright. I did that all over the state with the Australian Arts Council at 18. Then I joined the main company at 18.

So I was probably the youngest that had ever joined their main company. And I was very blessed with that because that was what they called in-service training then. It was like repertory.

So in those days, you either go to NIDA or if you're lucky enough, you're actually getting in-service training. So I did a series of 12 plays that year and I was doing a lot of training with them. And then I headed off to Sydney.

So that's how that all began. Yes. And when in Sydney, you were playing at the opera house, you had shows at the opera house, suddenly got into TV and you actually got into a very little-known show called the Rocky Horror Show as the lead performer.

I wasn't the lead. Frankfurdt is really the lead. I played Rocky in that, but I was involved in bands as well at that time and also did another rock opera in Sydney called Paradise Regains, which was there.

But after working at the Old Tote and then what is now called the Sydney Theatre Company, I ended up in Young Doctors for a few years. And then I went to the ABC and did a lot of shows with the ABC because that was the training that really embedded what I wanted to learn. I was hungry to learn to be a good actor then.

A lot of people in Australia would remember you from such fantastic series as 1915 and The Anzacs. Tell us about that. Well, yes.

Hey, Jeff. I think you've done a bit of homework on these old shows. Well, they're not so old, some of them.

Well, 1915 was a television series at the ABC where I played Wolf Lucas, which was about the First World War. And then the other one, of course, Anzacs was about the First World War as well. Anzacs was shot in Melbourne with the same mob that made Snowy River and Jeff Burrows and John Dixon.

And that was a highlight because I'd come from doing a lot of different things, a lot of ABC work and this and that and that. I was co-starring with Paul Hogan in that and a lot of really great actors. I mean, that's what you live for, when you can work with good actors and have a good time and get better and better at what you do.

We've spoken about the Rocky Horror Show and that would have been quite amazing. I do remember that show and you in it because I was in Australian radio back then too. It was a huge experience.

There's been a lot of versions of it. It's always worked in many different versions because there's Max Phipps, there's a whole lot of different, Michael McCaffrey. It's always a fun show and it's very memorable.

But I ended up getting thrown into films next and a band called Going Troppo, which we played around quite a bit. Your daughter is extremely famous and we'll get onto what you're doing shortly, but your daughter Tammy is one of the most famous influencers in Australia with millions of followers. Tammy She's doing very well, my Tam.

Yeah, I'm very proud of the girls. There's Tammy, my youngest, and there's Emily, the middle girl, and Amy, my oldest, and those three beautiful daughters. I'm very blessed to have in my life.

They had quite a lot of influence on me too at the time because when I was four, six and eight, I'd sort of walked away and I was writing a couple of film scripts. I'd come back from America because I'd been working in America and the Caribbean and different places and I've been in England and back and forth. And I ended up with them on my own with them at four, six and eight.

So Hollywood was very interested in having me over there and working, but I had to make the decision of where would I raise the three girls on my own at that time. And so it was, instead of going to LA and then the contracts, I went to Currumbin Valley, left Sydney, came up to Currumbin Valley and put them through school at the Currumbin Valley, little primary school out there. We had a great time out there for 10 years and I suppose they're doing very well.

I actually put it down to believe that, apart from cracking jokes about myself, but no, they're very self-made girls. They've done it on their own, even though they're now influencers. Tammy's got

about, I think, 17 million followers and Emily's got a million followers and Amy's got a few hundred thousand and they all work together, which I'm more pleased about that than anything.

I'd probably put that down to a bit of, they grew up in a very small school with a cow outside the door in a valley, which was only 80 students in the school at the time. And it was like a farm. So they grew up in a farm environment and a very simple environment and the simple things were important.

And I don't think it did them any harm because they've gone on then. After they were blessed to be able to go further on and have more worldly experiences with their mum and her new husband, who was back in their life, which was great, later on. They went to live in Singapore, for example, went to the Singapore school over there, which was a great blessing.

And they came back here and Tammy in the right place at the right time and Instagram was starting and she was having a baby and people started following and it just sort of started to grow and grow and grow and grow. And now they're very, very good business women and they've got businesses in fashion, beauty. Obviously, Tammy's got skin and the other, an app, a fitness app, you know.

I remember when I was growing up, I'd sort of, you know, pay a thousand dollars or something. Tammy would say, I want to do a yoga course. How much is that? That time I wasn't quite so financial.

And then I'd say, it's a thousand dollars. And they'd go, okay, I hope she's going to use this, I'll give her this. But now she's doing yoga on their app and things like, yes, yes, yes.

You know, they're very, very successful and they're good girls. They work hard and I'm very blessed. And they also try and make a difference in other people.

They're not just influencing, they represent people. You know, they're the real deal. You see a lot of sides of the world, that's for sure, by just being a father of them and seeing the good stuff and all the nonsense that goes on out there too.

And the lovers, the haters, you know, all the types out there, you know, but they're pretty good. They're good. One lady who is very famous now and who both of you and I know personally and their families is Margot Robbie.

I mean, I was a guest magician at Margot Robbie's 21st and you've known Margot since she was knee-high to a grasshopper, as we say in Australia, and her mum. Yes, that's a Queensland thing, Geoff, you know, being old. So I come from Queensland and then of course I lived in Sydney and I worked in Melbourne around the world and came back to Sydney and then back to Queensland.

We grew up, you know, the Hembroughs and my sort of family, my mum came from Toowoomba

and they knew the Kesslers and I had Uncle John Kessler, I used to call him Uncle John, Uncle Herb, which was Margot's grandfather. So they were friends through the Lutheran Church actually way, way, way back and we grew up with them, you know, Sari and Jackie, who I knew very well and of course Sari's had this, you know, beautiful family now and same with Jackie. It was interesting to know these young folk that were in Queensland themselves and then watch her work and strive for the success she's had.

It's terrific really. And she's probably the number one movie star in the world at the moment or one of the top five. Definitely.

Well, I think so. I think Tom and her, though they had the biggest grossing film in all time last year with Barbie, didn't they? That's enormous. That's huge.

But, you know, as I said there, you know, I've only actually talked to Margot once on a FaceTime where Sari rang me up with Margot Walken on Venice Beach. I talk to Sari quite a lot, but it's like all our kids, you know. That's Margot's mother.

Yeah, yeah, Sari, you know, and they said, oh, can you say a prayer for us? I said, oh, yeah, all right, because I've been doing a bit of that work. It's not religion, but I had trained to be the Minister of Health and all sorts of things. I was quite surprised.

I said, Sari, you can't put your daughter on. Like, I mean, the last time I actually saw Margot, she would have been like five, you know what I mean? Like, she's going, can you say a prayer for Margot? And I said, and there she was, saying hi, they're walking in Venice. And I said, didn't, and Margot said, yeah, yeah, yes, you can, yes, you can.

So I said, okay, here we go. I said, you know, Heavenly Father, we lift up Margot. You protect her in Hollywood.

Protect her from all the nonsense. You know, bind up the nonsense. May the angels stand tall next to her.

Make sure she is safe in Jesus' name. Amen. Brilliant.

Threw it out there, you know, and they went, yeah, thank you, thank you, thank you. So, you know, it was a delight to see that. You know, like the whole family of good folk, you know, as I said, I know her mum more than her, but I got to meet Tom when he was out here recently, which was briefly at the Actor Awards, and they actually hadn't, they didn't know who he was, and he was trying to get a seat to get inside.

And I said, follow me, mate. Anyway, here I was. I thought he was an interloper.

Yeah, yeah. I mean, here's the guy who's the producer of the biggest film in the world history, you know what I'm saying? Come in this door. It's all right, it's all right.

Your seat's down there next to Margot, down the pub's the usher. That's brilliant. I was never really good at awards.

Now, back to me, of course, you know, I'm the shining light of the Goldfish. No, no, no. I'm not really good at a lot of those things, you know, the awards either.

I'll tend to go to the bar next door, get FaceTime with someone inside, and then I'll have a, I very rarely drink, but maybe have a cocktail, you know, with Darth Davies, my mate, if I get a chance. Yeah. You, I heard that you interviewed the other day.

Well, we had a great interview with Darth. He's sitting here, Darth Davies, he's from, you know, Stuntman from the Matrix, Star Wars, you name it. He's been in it.

Mad Max, he's been in everything. Yeah, he works as Jeff's security now. That's right, that's right.

In case I say something bad, he'll throw me off the balcony, then run down the stairs and catch me at the bottom. I worked a lot with a lot of these fun people that you're obviously interviewing in Australia over those years. What you're up to now, we're chatting with Mark Hembrough, who's the fantastic actor, producer, and now movie director, and working on a few projects.

I've got one here, Wilfred, and a couple of others. Tell us about what you're up to. Yes, well, at the moment, we're just completing a kids film called Crypto Kids.

It's a low-budget independent film that we've shot on the Gold Coast and in the hinterland called Crypto Kids, and it's looking very, very cool. I'm very happy with it. Everyone's really cool that's in it.

And so that's a Hembrough production, and that'll be out in about three to four months. Far as that away, not too long. We're in final stages of editing with that, and I'm working with Jason Gann on the new Wilfred series, as well as a producer.

I'll co-direct his first couple of episodes, it seems, at the moment. He's another person that's ended up washed up on Queensland. We're like castaways who have been washed up in Surfers Paradise, which is a really terrible place to be washed up.

It's awful here. We're sitting out here with the- Hello, Laura Keats. The birds are here.

And we're 20 stories up at the Mantua. It's absolutely gorgeous here overlooking the beach. If you were going to be washed up anywhere, this is the place.

This is the place, and I love to castaways coffee shop across the road at the Merritton on the beach, but it is, yes. I'm working with the first episode of Jason's new production, Wilfred, which you may have seen, people may not have seen. It's a sort of comedy.

It's set in the Gold Coast, and of course Crypto Kids was all set in the Gold Coast, and that's nearly finished, so we're really working out of a place that we'd love to be, and we're sort of organically creating these shows and writing them out of here as well. So we star our characters, and we star the Gold Coast, really. So that's going down.

We've got a couple of other films that we're negotiating with at the moment, both as an actor and also as a writer. We've got two other bigger shows that were written over the last few years, one of them when I was out in the valley with the kids way back, because I put down- I said no to acting for 20 years. Now I'm acting again.

I'm co-starring in Crypto Kids as well, as well as being the writer-director, because as I said, it's a low budget, and I was cheap and available. Well, as you get older, you tend to get a bit cheaper occasionally, but the thing is, we also have the fantastic facility of Movie World here on the Gold Coast, which is a great, great facility. Well, yes, it's attracted many, many, many films.

They're coming there, you know. With the tariffs and everything else going on, I think things will change a little bit, but it's all set up. There's the people here.

I'm working a bit more on organically grown Australian for international market, in that sense, only because they're what we're doing at the moment, because I'm blessed to be able to be the writer, the director, and the actor, and have a crew and a team of people around us, so we're doing what we want. And also, we're doing a lot of funny stuff. Well, Mark Hembrough, it's been fascinating to catch up with you here on the Gold Coast and hear about all your projects and your fascinating past.

Can you say hello to our audience out there? We broadcast on a lot of radio stations in Australia and overseas. Yes, I'd like to say hello to Travel Radio Australia, everyone that's out there. We send our love and our best cheer from the Hembroughs, from all the mob on Queensland, all the mob in Sydney and Melbourne, all the stuntmen, all the ridiculous people I've got to work with, including myself.

But we send our love out to you all and keep your ears growing for Travel Radio, okay? It's a good show. Thank you very much, Mark Hembrough. It's been a pleasure.

Thanks, Geoff. It's been a pleasure to have a chat with you, mate.